

TATA INSTITUTE OF SOCIAL SCIENCES, TULJAPUR



SEMESTER VI FIELD WORK REPORT

Survey Conducted in Tuljapur and Kakarmba

COURSE: B.A. SOCIAL SCIENCES (2022-2026)

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ENROLMENT NO:

T2022BA001

T2022BA009

T2022BA032

Introduction

The report analyses Socio-Economic data of 6 households from Kakarmba village and Tuljapur rural area. From a structured as well as an unstructured set of questionnaires, the focus of the report has been to collect data on various development indicators such as demographic particulars, education, health, living conditions, livelihoods, migration, household belongings, indebtedness, social identity, intra-household dynamics, poverty status, and access to social assistance schemes.

The purpose of the report is to present all sets of data and understand the relationship between two or more indicators, as well as draw inferences from the diverse profiles of households. Although the study was confined to only 6 households, our in-depth study has brought a wide range of results, which many times support as well as sometimes contradict the existing literature findings, and this report has put forth all these results.

Methodology

The survey utilized a mixed-methods approach, combining structured interviews and direct observations to gather qualitative and quantitative data. Households were purposively selected to represent diverse castes, occupations, and economic statuses within the community. Data collection encompassed demographic characteristics, income sources, expenditure patterns, access to resources, social participation, and perceptions of inequality and discrimination. Key indicators included per capita income, the Gini coefficient, and a modified MPI. Limitations include the small sample size (seven households) and missing income data for one household, which may affect the generalizability and accuracy of findings.

Agriculture and Rural Economy

In our survey, out of 7 households, 6 households were exclusively or partially dependent of agriculture and related activities. The major crops here in the region are soybeans, jowar, bajra, wheat, and onions.

Almost all households are aware of government schemes in the agriculture sector and are beneficiaries of the PM Krishi Samman Yojana. Sudhakar Bhavakar and Bedge Mahesh Kalidas also have an agricultural loan under government schemes. Only two households have irrigation facilities, and therefore, other households have difficulties in doing year-round farming. In this case, Jwar, bajra, and similar kinds of drought-resilient crops are preferred by farmers.

Household respondent Name	Agricultural Land Area (in acres)	Other Income sources
1. Kasturi Rao	3 acre (Not cultivated by themselves)	Hotel in Tuljapur
2. Sudhakar Bhavakar	5 acre	Shop & one private job
3. Naineswar Mali	2 acre	Security job at TISS
4. Bedge Mahesh Kalidas	3.5 acre	Delivery person of an e-commerce company
5. Vedika Devanand	2-3 acres	Tailoring
6. Household 6 (Name withheld for anonymity)	NA	Worker at TISS

Education

Although the education levels of respondents and heads of households vary, all households have prioritized education for their children. This demonstrates that people are recognizing the benefits associated with education. Households are ambitious for their children and are ready to spend on their higher education, even through loans in some cases.

There is a noticeable relationship between the caste of a household and the education level of its members. For instance, Kasturi Rao, who is a Brahmin, has completed a Bachelor of Commerce. Sudhakar Bhavkar, who belongs to the OBC (Other Backward Classes), has completed a Bachelor of Arts. In contrast, both Vedika Devanand and her husband, who are from the Scheduled Caste, have only completed up to the 12th grade.

The education level of the people in the household also has a relationship with the income level. However, it cannot be concluded from our survey that what causes what or what are the other factors that also influenced the income level.

Health

The fieldwork revealed that **healthcare access** is shaped as much by formal infrastructure as by **gender roles, occupational vulnerability, and social exclusion**. While schemes like **Ayushman Bharat** were accessed by several households (71% as per survey), the **actual usage of these schemes was limited**. For instance, Kasturi Rao's household is enrolled in Ayushman Bharat, yet it is unclear whether the scheme covered her hospitalisation for chikungunya. Similarly, Maushi, despite suffering from chronic high blood pressure, reported no insurance coverage—her reason being a belief that her low income disqualifies her. This reflects a **gap between policy design and ground-level access**, exacerbated by misinformation and administrative hurdles.

Among agricultural labourers and informal workers, **health shocks directly affect survival**. The woman labourer who earns ₹300/day shared that even when sick, she must go to work—since losing a day's wage means having no money to feed the family. Her case reveals the **feminisation of health insecurity**: women bear the burden of earning, caregiving, and coping with illness, often without rest, support, or treatment.

Infrastructure-wise, most households had access to clean water and basic sanitation, though drinking water often came at a cost (e.g., ₹30 per jar in Sudhakar Bhavakar's case). But **access does not imply adequacy**—safe drinking water and private toilets were not universally present. Moreover, the complete lack of asset-based health security (e.g., refrigerators for medicine storage, transportation to clinics) compounds vulnerability.

Thus, the field reveals **layered health inequalities**: public infrastructure exists, but **socio-economic class, gender, and caste influence both access and health-seeking behaviour**.

Gender Roles

Gender roles within households followed a largely **patriarchal structure**, especially in decision-making and control over finances. In at least four of the surveyed households, **men (husbands or fathers) were the primary decision-makers**, while women were relegated to unpaid domestic work or supporting roles in family-based economic activity.

However, this surface-level pattern masks significant **informal economic contributions by women**. Maushi, a widow, works at TISS and cooks in two homes, sustaining herself and occasionally contributing to the larger family. The woman agricultural labourer not only works

but is also the **sole breadwinner** in her household due to her husband's alcoholism and violence. These cases challenge the passive image of women in rural economies and highlight the **economic agency of women despite social constraints**.

Importantly, **power does not always follow income**. Even where women earn, like in Kasturi Rao's case, **key decisions are made by men**. Her future labour is planned not around retirement or health but around her daughter's marriage, showing how **women's economic lives are still linked to familial transitions** rather than autonomy.

Moreover, **women's labour is undervalued**: working despite illness (as in Kasturi's case) or juggling multiple informal jobs (as with Maushi) is considered "natural" and expected. Only one woman, facing domestic violence and earning for survival, explicitly illustrated how gender intersects with vulnerability to **both economic and emotional insecurity**.

Overall, **gender roles within households reflect a contradiction**: women are indispensable to household survival, yet lack decision-making power, financial independence, or adequate support systems.

Poverty

Measured by both **income-based and multidimensional indicators**, poverty in the surveyed households manifested in **visible and invisible forms**. Using the official 2023–24 poverty line of ₹1,632 per capita per month for rural areas, one household fell below the line (the woman earning ₹300/day, i.e., ₹9,000/month for a family of 5). However, when a higher benchmark of ₹2,515 per capita is used, at least **two households** fall into poverty, suggesting a **poverty incidence of around 31%**, and a **multidimensional poverty index (MPI) of approximately 10.48%**.

Material poverty was evident through **low asset ownership**. None of the households owned cars, refrigerators, or washing machines. Only one had multiple rooms (Sudhakar Bhavakar), but even he lacked many basic appliances. The **lack of assets weakens resilience**, especially when households face health emergencies, debt, or unemployment.

Informal financial networks like bachat ghats were more common among women (e.g., wives and mothers of the security guard). These networks served as **micro-resilience mechanisms**, helping with loans for agriculture or emergencies. However, some women, like Maushi,

remained excluded due to time poverty or lack of awareness, indicating uneven access to even these grassroots-level supports.

Crucially, poverty was not always tied to absolute deprivation—it often existed in **relative terms**, such as when a household was "middle class" by local standards but had **no savings or buffer against income shocks** (e.g., during COVID-19). The **decline in income post-pandemic** was a recurring theme, especially among self-employed workers like Sudhakar.

Lastly, caste overlays poverty. Lower-caste respondents (e.g., the woman labourer, Vedika, etc.) not only earned less but also **faced exclusion from temples and public events**, indicating **social poverty alongside economic deprivation**.

Inequality and Development

Overall average monthly income of a household is Rs 18,667 with per capita income in the range of Rs 1,800 to Rs 5,833. All rural households are above the 2023-24 poverty line of Rs 1,632 per capita for rural. However, applying a higher estimate of Rs 2,515, two households (12 individuals) are below, suggesting a 41.38% poverty rate among rural individuals.

The Multidimensional Poverty Index (MPI) is approximated using four indicators:

- **Education:** School attendance (weight 1/3).
- **Standard of Living:** Clean water, sanitation, food security (each weight 1/9).

Poor household (deprivation score is $\geq 1/3$). Multi-dimensional poverty entails (12 people, 2 households) or a mere 31.43% poverty rate; an average of 1/3 for deprivation intensity leads to a somewhat around 10.48% MPI poorness.

Table 1: Per Capita Income and Poverty Status

Household	Per Capita Income ()	Poverty Status
Kasturi Rao	2,857	Above
Sudhakar Bhavakar	5,833	Above
Name Withheld (300/day)	1,800	Below
Naineswar Mali	2,429	Above
Bedge Mahesh Kalidas	4,000	Above
Name Withheld (Urban)	2,500	Above

Table 2: Household Income and Poverty Status

Household	Monthly Income (INR)	Members	Per Capita Income (INR)
Kasturi Rao	20,000	7	2,857
Sudhakar Bhavakar	35,000	6	5,833
Name Withheld (300/day)	9,000	5	1,800
Naineswar Mali	17,000	7	2,429
Bedge Mahesh	16,000	4	4,000
Vedika Devanand	Not specified	6	Not calculated
Name Withheld (Joint)	15,000	3	2,500

Inequality

Economic Inequality

Household incomes vary from 9,000 INR to 35,000 INR per month, demonstrating the span of economics within society. Table 3 with the followed income data in the surveyed households

Table 3: Household Income Data

Household Identifier	Monthly Income (INR)
Kasturi Rao	20,000
Sudhakar Bhavakar	35,000 (midpoint of 30,000–40,000)
Name Withheld (300/day)	9,000
Naineswar Mali	17,000
Bedge Mahesh	16,000
Name Withheld (Joint Family)	15,000
Vedika Devanand	Not specified

To quantify income inequality, the Gini coefficient was calculated using the formula:

$$G = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^n \sum_{j=1}^n |x_i - x_j|}{2n \sum_{i=1}^n x_i}$$

where x_i and x_j are household incomes, and n is the number of households. Excluding the household with unspecified income, the incomes are: 9,000; 15,000; 16,000; 17,000; 20,000;

35,000 INR. The Gini coefficient is approximately 0.217, indicating moderate income inequality. However, the small sample size limits the robustness of this measure. Nationally, India's income Gini coefficient is estimated at around 0.33 to 0.41 in recent years, suggesting that the sample may underrepresent broader inequality.

The income range is huge from Name Withheld (9,000 INR /month) to 40,000 INR (Sudhakar Bhavakar). Similarly, the asset ownership such as land or household belongings will also vary even within this tiny sample indicating there is some economic variation.

Development Policy

Government schemes are pretty much accessible to all households; some are even getting benefit from Ayush man Bharat or ration cards and most certainly Kisan Yojana. Yet the effect has been marginal based on reporting, indicating sparse impact in meeting household needs. Organizations are not integrated with the formal banking channels at the margin as indicated by awareness and access through banks but some constraints might exist among vulnerable households.

Table 4: Poverty Indicators

Household	Per Capita Income (Rs)	Below Rs 1,632	Below Rs 2,515
Kasturi Rao	2,857	No	No
Name Withheld (300/Day)	1,800	No	Yes
Sudhakar Bhavakar	5,833	No	No
Naineswar Mali	2,429	No	Yes
Bedge Mahesh Kalidas	4,00	No	No

Population, Urbanization, and Development

Demographic Particulars

Average household size 5.83 (children, adults and elderly). The gender split is roughly even, with plenty of male and female roles where members are interacting with each other mostly directed by men.

Migration and Rural-Urban Linkages

Some households such as Kasturi Rao (from places like Karnataka), migrated (to semi-urban places like Tuljapur). Others have not migrated per se indicating rural roots (Sudhakar

Bhavakar). Some admit to having access to urban services like public transport, suggesting rural-urban linkages.

Livelihood Profile

Diverse earning streams like agriculture, private jobs and revenue (security work, delivery services, tailoring etc.), institutional jobs (like TISS). The mean monthly household income is 18,677, showing general economic abilities but lots of variations.

Table 5: Income Sources and Average Income

Metric	Value
Main Income Source	Agriculture, jobs, tailoring, etc
Average Monthly Income	18,667

Household Belongings

Low asset ownership (0% for TVs, phones, refrigerators, vehicles) suggests a basic standard of living, potentially indicative of economic constraints.

Indebtedness

Some households, like Name Withheld (300 per day), report incurring debt or reducing food consumption, indicating financial stress. Others report no such issues, suggesting varying economic resilience.

Social Identity and Social Capital

Caste and Religion

The households were from different castes Households: Brahmin, OBC (Pujari & Mali) SC (Dhangar), Maratha and Dhangar (lingayat) in every village. All Hindu except one Lingayat households. Segregation of caste, out of all castes OBC, SC face significant bottlenecks: visiting temples while Brahmin has little challenges.

Caste significantly influences access to resources, as reported by the households:

- **Kasturi Rao (Brahmin):** Commented, "Lower caste would suffer more since they are not so hard workers", showing a potential stereotype and bias but talking about hard life of lower castes.

- ***Sudhakar Bhavakar (OBC)*** and ***Anonymous (Dhamgar)***: Both reported "Very much, entry in temple not allowed," indicating explicit social and religious discrimination, which can limit community participation and economic opportunities.
- ***Bedge Mahesh Kalidas (OBC)*** and ***Vedika Devanand (SC)***: Stated "Very much," suggesting significant influence, though without specific details, likely due to systemic barriers faced by lower castes.

This is consistent with empirical studies on caste discrimination in India, noting the social exclusion and paucity of resources for those of lower castes. The data cries for policies, to tackle the caste-based impediments to social inclusion and economic progress.

Community Engagement

Only 14.29% (1 out of 7) are members of community organizations, but 57.14% participate in local events or governance, indicating moderate social capital.

Table 6: Social Identity and Engagement

Household	Caste	Community Participation
Kasturi Rao	Hindu Brahmin	No
Sudhakar Bhavakar	Pujari (OBC)	Yes
Name Withheld (300/day)	Dhamgar	No
Naineswar Mali	OBC Mali	Yes
Bedge Mahesh Kalidas	OBC	Yes
Vedika Devanand	SC, Dhangar	Yes
Name Withheld (Joint)	Maratha	No

Intra-Household Aspects

Decision-Making

Major expenditure decisions are typically made by:

- Males (husband or father) in four households.
- Females in two households, where males are absent or non-contributory (e.g., due to alcoholism or death).
- Both husband and wife in one household.

Household Chores

Women predominantly handle chores, with men assisting in one household. Women also contribute economically, particularly in self-help groups or labour, in some cases.

Field Reflections

One of the most important takeaways from the fieldwork was how everyday realities do not always match textbook categories. Health, gender roles, caste, and livelihoods intersect in ways that shape what people can and cannot do — often quietly, and often without formal recognition.

A moment that stayed with me was when **Kasturi Rao remarked that “lower caste people can’t work as hard as us.”** This wasn’t said with hostility, but casually — and that made it more revealing. It showed how caste-based ideas about worth and work continue to circulate in everyday life. What stood out even more was the contradiction: Kasturi’s own family had faced subtle exclusion as South Indian migrants, yet caste privilege still shaped her perception of others. This reminded me that **caste operates not only through visible exclusion, but also through internalised beliefs and language.**

Gender roles followed a similar pattern. Women often carried much of the burden — working, caring, and managing the household — but were excluded from decision-making or institutional support. For example, Maushi has worked for over 20 years and supports herself, yet she’s not part of any bachat ghat or formal credit system. The woman labourer we spoke to was both the breadwinner and the primary caregiver, yet lived in a relative’s house, owned no land, and remained outside any scheme. These examples show how **economic contribution by women doesn’t always translate into greater control or support**, either within the household or from the state.

In terms of **health**, it was clear that work takes priority. Respondents like Kasturi or the woman labourer continued working even while unwell, because not working simply wasn’t an option. Health schemes like Ayushman Bharat were mentioned, but usage was limited. For many, rest was a luxury they couldn’t afford. This made it clear that **access to care is not just about hospitals or insurance, but also about time, money, and the ability to stop working — which many respondents did not have.**

An important shift I noticed was around **agriculture**. While several households owned land, it was not central to their identity or income. Kasturi's family pays for the maintenance of a family field, but they don't farm it. Sudhakar Bhavakar's household has five acres, but their primary income comes from a shop. This suggests that for many rural families, **agriculture has become a symbolic or fallback asset rather than a mainstay of livelihood**. This reflects a broader shift in rural economies, where people combine land ownership with non-farm work — or move away from farming altogether when it becomes too uncertain or unviable.

Finally, while government schemes like ration cards, PM Kisan, and Ayushman Bharat were known to most respondents, their practical impact was limited. Some believed they weren't eligible; others lacked time or clarity about how to apply. **Formal coverage often didn't lead to real support** — and this gap between entitlement and access came up repeatedly.

Overall, the field reminded me that **people's decisions are shaped by overlapping constraints** — economic pressure, gendered responsibility, social identity, and limited institutional access. These aren't always visible in data, but they emerge clearly in daily conversations, routines, and silences. Listening to those details helped me understand not just what people live with, but how they navigate systems that often leave them to manage on their own.

Conclusion

The results of the field survey highlight a resiliently educated community but one susceptible to income precarity, resource inequity and enduring class inequity on the reservation. Market access and skill gaps are plaguing agricultural households but sanitation gaps, along with limited working of social services pose problem for social sector patterns. In that control of economics are only moderate (Gini = 0.217) minor migration disruption aside, caste and gender further perpetuate the dynamics of restricted opportunities available to disadvantaged groups. Multi-dimensional poverty 2011 affects approximate 31% of individuals, reflecting structural weaknesses. Government schemes are there, but the system yields little tangible outcomes. Ensuring concrete gains in living standards will require focused interventions on agriculture, boosting scheme implementation, and progressive inclusive policies that reach from caste to gender and resource justice.